

PLACEMENT EXPERIENCE – BARCLAYS GSC

Note: Internship to Full-Time Conversion

Before transitioning into my current full-time role at Barclays GSC Chennai, I initially joined the company as a summer intern. The process I am about to describe reflects the experience I had during my internship placement. This internship was later converted into a full-time position, based on my performance. Therefore, the steps and experiences detailed below pertain specifically to the internship selection process.

ABOUT THE COMPANY

Barclays is a British multinational investment bank and financial services company headquartered in London. With a history dating back over 325 years, Barclays operates in more than 40 countries, offering products and services across personal, corporate, and investment banking. The company is committed to helping customers and clients achieve their financial goals through innovation and a focus on responsible banking.

Barclays in India: Barclays has established a strong footprint in India, where it operates through various business units. The bank provides services in areas such as investment banking, where it advises companies on mergers, acquisitions, and capital raising; corporate banking, offering tailored financial solutions to large corporations; and wealth management, catering to high-net-worth individuals with bespoke investment strategies.

Barclays Global Service Centre (GSC): Barclays GSC is an integral part of Barclays' global operations, providing critical services that support the bank's business worldwide. Barclays GSC is a network of centres that support the bank's operations worldwide, with a focus on delivering technology and operational services. These centres are critical to Barclays' ability to operate efficiently and innovate in the competitive financial services industry.

At **Barclays GSC Chennai**, where I work, the focus is on delivering technology-driven solutions and operational support that are crucial to Barclays' global business operations. The centre specializes in areas like data engineering, software development, and operational risk management. Teams here collaborate with global counterparts to ensure the smooth functioning of Barclays' operations across various regions, playing a pivotal role in the bank's success.

ABOUT THE ROLE

Internship Role: During my internship at Barclays GSC Chennai, I worked as a UI Developer. My primary responsibility was to develop a documentation portal intended for internal use by other team members. The team I was part of specializes in creating UI libraries for other departments within Barclays. The portal we developed served as a comprehensive documentation resource for these libraries.

The project involved using front-end technologies such as React.js and HTML to create a dynamic and user-friendly interface. Additionally, we utilized a tool called Docusaurus, which automates the creation of documentation websites by generating content from codebase documentation. This was not just a static website; it dynamically pulled and displayed documentation, making it easier for users to access and understand the UI components. I collaborated closely with another intern on this project, and we successfully delivered a functional and well-documented portal over the course of our two-month internship.

Current Full-Time Role: After my internship, I transitioned into a full-time role at Barclays GSC Chennai, where I now work as a Data Engineer. In this role, I am responsible for managing the ETL (Extract, Transform, Load) process, a critical component of data engineering. My work involves using a specialized tool called Ab Initio, which streamlines and automates the ETL process, ensuring that data is efficiently processed and made available for analytical and operational use.

PREPARATION STRATEGY

To prepare for the placement/intern process, I focused on strengthening my problem-solving skills and revisiting key technical concepts. I spent time practicing coding problems on HackerRank, which helped me brush up on essential DSA topics. Additionally, I reviewed the basics of DBMS, SDLC, computer networks as well as all the other core subjects. These areas were crucial for the online test round.

The online test round included two coding questions of easy to medium difficulty, mainly focused on basic DSA concepts, and several multiple-choice questions (MCQs) covering various topics such as DBMS, networks, and SDLC. Preparing for these topics allowed me to approach the test confidently.

Once I cleared the online test, I intensified my preparation by revisiting core subjects, including DBMS, SDLC, and DSA, as well as other fundamental topics. This thorough review was essential for the next stage of the selection process—the interview.

PLACEMENT DRIVE EXPERIENCE (ONLINE TEST, GD, TECHNICAL AND HR INTERVIEWS)

The placement process consisted of two rounds: the online test and a combined technical and HR interview.

Online Test: The online test featured two coding questions that were relatively straightforward, focusing on basic DSA concepts. These questions were not too challenging and did not involve complex topics like graphs. Additionally, there were multiple-choice questions that covered a wide range of subjects, including DBMS, networks, and SDLC. The preparation I had done prior to the test proved very helpful in navigating this round successfully.

Interview: After passing the online test, I participated in an online interview with a senior colleague based in Pune. The interview followed a standard format, beginning with an introduction. I was asked a series of questions on DBMS, which were fairly basic. When asked about my favourite subject, I mentioned Operating Systems (OS), leading to a few questions on that topic as well.

The interviewer also inquired about my projects, specifically asking how I contributed to them and their current status. Since the interview was conducted online, I was able to demonstrate my work by showing project demos, which I had prepared in advance. Additionally, I was asked a question related to computer networks. The interview concluded with a question about why I wanted to join Barclays, which provided an opportunity to express my interest in the company. Overall, the placement process was straightforward, with only two rounds—the online test and the combined technical and HR interview.

TIPS AND TRICKS

1. Strengthen Core Subjects and Fundamentals

Revisiting and mastering the fundamentals of your core subjects is crucial. Whether it's DBMS, Operating Systems, or Networks, having a solid understanding of these topics will set you up for success, especially during technical interviews.

2. Focus on Data Structures and Algorithms (DSA)

DSA concepts are instrumental in clearing the first round—typically the online test—of most placement processes. This round is often the most challenging, so regular practice of DSA problems is essential. Use platforms like HackerRank or LeetCode to hone your skills.

3. Build a Strong Portfolio with Project Demos

A well-rounded portfolio with diverse projects is a great way to showcase your skills. Whenever possible, have demos ready for your projects, as this can significantly enhance your profile during interviews. Working on various projects across different tech stacks not only broadens your knowledge but also boosts your confidence.

4. Craft a Simple and Clear Resume

Your resume should be concise and focused, ideally fitting on a single page. It should clearly outline your skill set, projects, experience, and education. Don't forget to include any certifications, technical events, or competitions you've participated in.

5. Participate in Technical Events and Hackathons

Engaging in intra- and inter-college technical events, as well as hackathons, is highly beneficial. These experiences not only help you learn new concepts but also enhance your resume. Plus, they provide valuable experience working under pressure and in team settings.

6. Be Honest and Confident in Interviews

During interviews, confidence is key. Speak clearly and be honest about what you know. If you don't know the answer to a question, it's better to admit it than to try and bluff your way through. Authenticity goes a long way in making a positive impression.

7. Research the Company

Before any interview or even the online test round, take the time to research the company. You'll likely be asked why you want to join the company, so being well-prepared with knowledge about their mission, values, and recent projects will help you answer confidently and convincingly.